

The *write* process

The rules and steps we plan to follow to turn a researched topic into a published article. We want your expert read on it before we lock it in.

How to review this. Each section ends with a green prompt. Tell us where it is **right**, where it is **wrong**, and what is **missing**. Be blunt. The point is to catch bad rules now, not after we have written a hundred articles on them.

- 01 How an article gets made, the steps
- 02 The format playbooks, nine shapes
- 03 The publish checklist, every box a page must pass
- 04 How revisions work
- 05 The guardrails we hold

How an article gets made

Eight steps, in order, from a researched topic to a live page. Research has already found the sources, the structure, and the keywords. This process selects, words, places, and then proves the article, in the right sequence.

1 **Plan** the outline

Look up the format and load its playbook. Pick which sections make the article from the research menu, in the order the format sets. There is no fixed section count: the format and a "does this section earn its place" test decide it, never padding to hit a word count. Freeze the outline so every later step checks against it.

2 **Write** section by section

Write each section from its researched facts, in our brand voice. Place internal links. Order: body first, then the FAQ, then the intro, summary box, and close, then the page title and description last (they describe the finished article).

3 **Clean** mechanical

Strip invisible characters, fix spacing, remove stray dashes. No judgment, no rewriting.

4 **Measure** automated checks

Run every countable check: keyword placement, links resolve, every stat has a source, headings in order, meta lengths, no competitor domain, plus the format's own checks. Results feed the next steps. Full list in Part 03.

5 **Review** editorial judgment

A judgment pass on what a script cannot see: does each section deliver on its heading, is a comparison fair, is a product mention natural, has anything drifted off topic, is the snippet answer genuinely liftable. Findings sorted into critical, high, and quick-win.

6 **Edit** improve, then de-slop

First add craft: sharpen vague words with the real numbers, vary sentence rhythm, tighten lists. Then a dedicated pass to strip AI-writing tells. Facts never change in editing.

7 **Gate** pass or fix

Check the article against one publish checklist (Part 03). Pass and it ships. Fail a box and it goes back for a targeted fix, up to three tries, then to a person with notes.

8 **Publish** and make it findable

Push to the site as a draft, confirm the page is indexed by Google and by the index AI search reads from, with the answer text in plain HTML. Mark the topic done.

FOR YOUR REVIEW

Is this the right sequence, and does anything important happen too early or too late? Flag any step you would add, cut, or reorder.

☐ Right ☐ Wrong ☐ Missing

The format playbooks

A great list and a great report are built differently. Every article is a fixed wrapper (answer-first intro, summary box, five-question FAQ, forward-looking close) around a body that changes with the format. Below is how each of the nine shapes is built and checked. This is the part we most want your eyes on.

How-to and pillar guide

When: a task to complete, or a broad topic to map. Not "what is X" and not "best X."

SHAPE

- ☐ **One mode only.** Steps for a how-to, orient-and-route for a pillar. Never blend them.
- ☐ **Definition apart.** The "what is X" bit is its own section, never inside the steps.
- ☐ **Pillars stay broad.** Depth lives in the cluster articles they link to.
- ☐ **Table of contents.** Sticky for long pillars.

PER-STEP CRAFT

- ☐ **Verb first.** One action per step.
- ☐ **Set the scene.** Goal and location before the action, result right after.
- ☐ **One way only.** The shortest path, not a menu of methods.

CHECKS

- ☐ **Schema:** Article or BlogPosting, plus BreadcrumbList and FAQPage.

Hard rule: do not bury the task under theory.

Listicle

When: a set of discrete items (best-of, interview questions, tips, facts). Not a single-topic explainer.

SHAPE

- ☐ **Match the intent.** Plain list for info; a comparison table on top for buying queries.
- ☐ **Extras go below.** Pros and cons or a buying guide sit under the list, not before it.
- ☐ **Right item count.** 10 to 20 is the sweet spot; match the search results. 8+ unlocks the "more items" link, but only if real.
- ☐ **Depth over count for B2B.** Seven researched items beat fifteen shallow ones.

PER-ITEM CRAFT

- ☐ **Same template every item.** Heading, one-line summary, two or three short paragraphs, one proof.
- ☐ **Describe the thing,** not your article. No "in this list we..."
- ☐ **Order with logic.** Ranked = best first with disclosed criteria; process = basic to advanced; facts = most surprising first.

CHECKS

- ☐ **Flat list.** No nesting; it blocks snippets.
- ☐ **Numbered items.**
- ☐ **Contents block** for lists over ten items.
- ☐ **Schema:** ItemList, honestly reflecting the page.

Hard rule: every item earns its place. Cut filler even if it drops below eight.

Comparison and rankings

When: choosing between named options (best tools, X vs Y, alternatives). Not a single concept.

SHAPE

- ☐ **Set criteria first.** Decide the scoring dimensions and inclusion rules before looking at tools, and publish them.
- ☐ **Table up top.** Five lean columns, after a short intro that names the winner in line one.
- ☐ **"A vs B" fixed order.** What is A, what is B, differences, similarities, head-to-head, pros and cons each, verdict by use case, FAQ.
- ☐ **Real HTML table,** not a screenshot. Company blurb goes last.

FAIRNESS (THE SPINE)

- ☐ **Same block per option.** Overview, features, pricing model, one strength, one honest weakness, a verdict.
- ☐ **Facts, not adjectives.** "\$12 a month for five users", not "affordable".
- ☐ **A weakness for everyone,** including the option we favour.
- ☐ **Concede a real win** and point the reader to it.
- ☐ **A "which is better" line** in under 60 words.
- ☐ **Show real use.** Screenshots of each tool; say how many you tested and how you scored them.

CHECKS

- ☐ **Blank, not guessed.** Unknown cells stay empty.
- ☐ **Date every metric.** Flag a stale option with a date, never delete it silently.
- ☐ **Schema:** Review or Rating and Pros-and-Cons, only where real on the page.

Hard rule: never name or rank a direct assessment competitor. "Alternative to" links point at a category, not a rival.

Answer-bait and definitional

When: a concept to define ("what is X", "how does X work"). Not a task and not a set.

SHAPE

- ☐ **Answer at the very top.** 40 to 60 words, nothing above it.
- ☐ **Then widen out.** Definition, how it works, types, why it matters, examples, related questions.
- ☐ **Format fits the query.** Paragraph for what-is, list for steps, table for specs.

CRAFT

- ☐ **A 45-word answer.** Restate the term, define, qualify, outcome.
- ☐ **Each section stands alone.** Reads fine with its heading removed; no "this" or "as above".
- ☐ **Stat plus a quote.** Both lift how often AI cites the page.

CHECKS

- ☐ **Can it rank top 10?** Snippets and AI answers come from pages already ranking.
- ☐ **Schema:** DefinedTerm plus Article; the schema definition matches the on-page one word for word.

Hard rule: answer first, self-contained. No keyword stuffing, which measurably lowers citation.

Data and benchmark report

When: numbers to present for citations and links. A roundup of public stats can be written now; original research waits for the data.

SHAPE

- ☐ **Big number up front.** State the sample size in the intro.
- ☐ **Findings menu on top.** Then 8 to 15 findings, each a new number.
- ☐ **Show the method,** in-page and in full at the bottom.
- ☐ **Method fields:** sample size, source, dates, exactly what was measured, limits.
- ☐ **No form wall.**
- ☐ **Cut the obvious.** Drop findings that only confirm what everyone knows.

PER-FINDING CRAFT

- ☐ **Heading is the finding,** in words, with the exact number one line below.
- ☐ **A takeaway box each,** on ~200 to 400 words of context.
- ☐ **One-sentence stat.** Number, subject, scope, no dangling "it".
- ☐ **Lead with the crunchy stat.** It becomes the link text others use.

CHARTS

- ☐ **Name the relationship first,** then pick the chart. "Versus average" is a diverging bar, not a plain column.
- ☐ **One chart, one idea.** The title is a full takeaway sentence, not a label. Strip the clutter.

CHECKS

- ☐ **Schema:** Dataset on original research, plus Article and BreadcrumbList.

Hard rule: no disclosed method means it reads as marketing. Never gate it.

Glossary

When: many short term entries under one hub.

SHAPE

- ☐ **One A-to-Z hub** links to every entry.
- ☐ **Fixed entry shape.** Term as heading, "[Term] is..." first line, why it matters, a real example.
- ☐ **40 to 60 word definition**, plain text, not inside a styled box.
- ☐ **Link sideways.** Three to five related terms per entry.

CRAFT

- ☐ **Split the meanings.** Name each sense, do not blend them.
- ☐ **Spell out acronyms** on first use.
- ☐ **Question-shaped headings.**

CHECKS

- ☐ **Hub and entry link both ways.**
- ☐ **Schema:** DefinedTerm per entry, DefinedTermSet on the hub.

Hard rule: no thin or near-duplicate entries.

Interactive tool

When: a competitor genuinely ranks a tool. Otherwise route to an article. We write the words around the tool; building the tool is separate.

SHAPE

- ☐ **Words wrap the tool.** Intro, how to use, why it matters, method, FAQ, links.
- ☐ **Sized wrapper.** Intro 150 to 200 words, how-to 200 to 300, why-it-matters 400 to 500 with data, method, FAQ of 6 to 8.
- ☐ **Method makes it citable.**

CRAFT

- ☐ **Explain the result.** What the score means, and the next step.

CHECKS

- ☐ **Crawlable, above the fold.** Real HTML, not an iframe Google cannot read.
- ☐ **Keyword** in the H1, first paragraph, title, and description.
- ☐ **Schema:** WebApplication.

Hard rule: never put a link-magnet tool behind a form.

Template and resource

When: an article plus a downloadable we can produce as text (template, checklist, cheat sheet).

SHAPE

- ☐ **Heading is the query.** "[Thing] template".
- ☐ **Preview first.** Show the asset before any ask.
- ☐ **What you get, then how to use it.** Lead with a hard-number stat block ("385 items across 11 categories").
- ☐ **Contents and back-to-top.** Group items by workflow, with a count per group.

CRAFT (IF THE ASSET IS A CHECKLIST)

- ☐ **Every item is action-led.** Checkbox, imperative title, priority badge, one-line why.
- ☐ **Define priority once.** Show one filled example.

CHECKS

- ☐ **Offer more than one format.** View, download, copy. No format lock-in.
- ☐ **Schema:** HowTo or FAQ, where the steps are genuinely there.

Hard rule: default to no email wall.

Case study

When: a real named customer, real numbers, and a real quote are collected and approved in writing. Currently blocked until sign-off.

SHAPE

- ☐ **Number in the title.** Then customer, challenge, solution, results, quote.
- ☐ **Result first.** A cold visitor does not trust us yet.

CRAFT

- ☐ **Every metric in context.** Baseline and timeframe.
- ☐ **Lead with the business number.**
- ☐ **Name the real obstacle** you hit; it builds trust.
- ☐ **Editorialise.** Pick the two or three moments that matter, do not transcribe everything.
- ☐ **A real quote every few paragraphs.**

CHECKS

- ☐ **Written approval** for every number, name, quote, and logo, or it does not ship.
- ☐ **Schema:** Article, with the author and credentials emphasised.

Hard rule: the test is "would the named customer recognise this and nod?" No invented customer, quote, or metric.

News, opinion, editorial, trends, frameworks

When: none of the above. These run on the shared rules, with no dedicated playbook.

Hard rule: for news, freshness matters more than depth.

THREE CORRECTIONS WE ARE BAKING IN ACROSS EVERY FORMAT

FAQ and how-to markup no longer earns a rich result (per Google's own docs). We keep FAQ sections for readers and AI lift, use the markup for machine-readability only, and never promise a search feature from it.

Index in Bing. AI search reads Bing's index, so a Google-only page is invisible to it. This becomes a publish-stage requirement.

Never gate a link asset. A form wall makes a page invisible to Google and to every AI engine, so anything meant to earn links or citations stays open.

FOR YOUR REVIEW

These are the rules that decide whether each type of page is built well. Where do you disagree, where is a rule too strict or too loose, and what would you add for any format you know better than we do?

☐ Right ☐ Wrong ☐ Missing

The publish checklist

The single gate every article passes before it goes live. Countable boxes are ticked by a script, judgment boxes by an editor. Nothing ships with a box unticked or a sourcing failure. Skim it, and mark any box you would change.

Content

- ☐ **Right length.** Within the band for the type, never padded.
- ☐ **Keywords chosen.** One primary, plus three to five related terms.
- ☐ **Genuinely useful.** Beats what ranks now; accurate, current, not thin.

Structure

- ☐ **One H1.** Keyword near the start, under 60 characters.
- ☐ **Sections fit the format.** Not a fixed number; each earns its place; clean heading hierarchy.
- ☐ **Answer-first intro.** Keyword in the first 100 words; summary box above the fold.
- ☐ **Snippet-ready answers.** 40 to 60 words under each question heading.
- ☐ **FAQ of five.** Close is a next step, not a recap.
- ☐ **Question headings.** Half or more, on question-led pages.
- ☐ **Real semantic HTML.** True headings and lists; answer text server-rendered, never in an image or behind a script.
- ☐ **No dividers** in the body. A table only where it genuinely helps.

Keywords

- ☐ **Primary placed right.** H1, first 100 words, a couple of headings, the close.
- ☐ **Variations read naturally.** No stuffing, no density target.

Links

- ☐ **Three-plus internal links.** Varied anchors, under 30% exact-match, never "click here", max two per paragraph.
- ☐ **One product link** where natural.
- ☐ **Two-plus external sources.** Credible primaries, correct link relationship.
- ☐ **No competitor.** Every link works.

AEO and GEO (answer engines, AI answers)

- ☐ **Direct answer** under each question heading, 40 to 60 words, four-plus citations.
- ☐ **Self-contained sections.** Around 200 to 400 words, one idea, readable if lifted out alone.
- ☐ **A source every 150 to 200 words,** inline-linked.
- ☐ **Quotable sentences.** One idea per section; a relevant video where it helps.
- ☐ **Bonus:** one original stat.

Sources and integrity

- ☐ **Every stat sourced.** Real URL, works, right year, checked on the page.
- ☐ **Spread the domains.** Three-plus, max two cites each; cite, do not promote.
- ☐ **Best source available.** Most credible and freshest.
- ☐ **Numbers agree** with each other.

Experience and authority

- ☐ **Author box** with credentials, never in the body; dates visible.
- ☐ **First-hand voice**; citations verified.

Meta

- ☐ **Title 50 to 60 chars** with the keyword.
- ☐ **Description 140 to 160** with keyword, value, a nudge to click.
- ☐ **Slug has the keyword**; all unique and on-intent.

Readability and images

- ☐ **Short and active.** 15 to 20 word sentences, two to four sentence paragraphs, a subheading every ~350 words.
- ☐ **Images light and labelled.** Compressed, keyword-aware alt, descriptive filenames.

Voice and honesty

- ☐ **On brand, in persona.**
- ☐ **Product only where it wins.** No fake customer, quote, or metric.

Schema

- ☐ **Valid types only**, matched to the format (see Part 02): ItemList, DefinedTerm, Review, Dataset, WebApplication, Article, and so on.
- ☐ **Validated** in Google's Rich Results Test before publish; every value mirrors the visible page.
- ☐ **FAQ and how-to markup for parsing only**, never expecting a rich result.

Ship

- ☐ **Clean gate.** No critical fail, no sourcing fail, the AI-writing pass has been run.

FOR YOUR REVIEW

This is the core. Which boxes are wrong or outdated, which numbers would you change (link counts, answer length, meta lengths), and what belongs on this list that is not here yet?

☐ Right ☐ Wrong ☐ Missing

How revisions work

Problems are caught at the smallest scale that can fix them, so a weak draft is corrected, not scrapped.

- **While writing.** Each section is checked the moment it is written and rewritten once if needed, while it is still a screen of text.
- **At the gate.** When the checklist fails, each failing box becomes a specific fix with the exact evidence (which line, which section), not a blind rewrite. The fix happens, the page is re-checked, and the title and description are re-confirmed if the wording changed.
- **Three tries, then a person.** A page that still fails after three passes ships as a draft to a review folder with notes on exactly what failed.
- **A structural miss goes back to planning.** If a whole section needs cutting, that is an outline problem, so the outline is rebuilt rather than the text patched.

FOR YOUR REVIEW

Is three retries the right cap, and are we right to send a repeat failure to a human rather than publishing it? Tell us if you would handle failures differently.

☐ Right ☐ Wrong ☐ Missing

The guardrails we hold

A few lines never bend, whatever else an article scores.

- **Every stat is sourced.** A real source URL that resolves, matches its year, and was verified on the page. Numbers that cannot be sourced are softened or cut, never invented.
- **No fabrication.** No invented customer, quote, or first-party result, even signposted as illustrative. A signposted "imagine a recruiter..." is fine; a made-up testimonial is not.
- **No competitor named or ranked.** An "alternative to" link points at a neutral category, never a rival.
- **Honest positioning.** The product appears only where it genuinely fits, in an honest "here is what it does and does not do" frame.
- **One gate, not many scores.** A single checklist is the only thing that says an article is ready, so there is no vague overall score to game.
- **Nothing unconfirmed.** Draft research (unverified stats, unapproved customer stories) stays out until a person signs it off.

FOR YOUR REVIEW

Are these the right lines to hold, and is any of them too strict for how you would actually work? Add any guardrail you think we are missing.

☐ Right ☐ Wrong ☐ Missing

The write process · review copy for the SEO team · please return with your Right / Wrong / Missing notes per section